fostering trust and confidence. Once victims felt secure, they invested larger sums—only to be systematically defrauded in a process chillingly known as 'pig butchering', where the target is 'fattened' with false success before being financially 'slaughtered'.

Shubham's specific role was to lure individuals into such fraudulent investment ventures. When he refused, he was subjected to confinement, beatings and electrocution. "I met hundreds of Indians, including those from my home state, alongside Pakistanis, Bangladeshis and Sri Lankans. Most complied under duress; a handful, however, became willing enforcers of the criminal enterprise. We were housed in fortified compounds, enclosed by towering walls crowned with spiked fences. Escape was unthinkable." After days of torture, Shubham's family paid Rs 2 lakh for his release. On December 25, 2023, he returned to India and filed a complaint against his friend's father and other perpetrators. Shubham's story is one of the few with a happy ending. Many remain trapped, their families navigating an endless maze of officials and intermediaries, searching for a lifeline that may never come.

THE NIA CRACKDOWN

The National Investigation Agency (NIA), which is spearheading India's efforts to dismantle this transnational trafficking network, has intensified its crackdown since May 2024. That month, the agency arrested five individuals, a Gopalganj native among them, in coordinated raids across six states in collaboration with local police forces. By June, the agency had filed chargesheets against five people, including two foreign nationals, for targeting Indian youths proficient in English and computer skills. In July, four key suspects were held in Delhi in a related case of human trafficking and cyber fraud linked to Laos and other Southeast Asian nations. The crackdown escalated further in November, with extensive searches targeting travel agents in Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Delhi, Maharashtra and Punjab.

In December, the agency achieved a significant breakthrough, apprehending Kamran Haider—alleged linchpin of the cyber slavery syndicate—who carried a cash reward of Rs 2 lakh. Haider, who operated under the guise of a consultancy firm, had been instrumental in arranging flight tickets and facilitating illegal border crossings for trafficked youth. Earlier, in September, the NIA had charge-sheeted Sudarshan Darade, CEO of a Laos-based firm, which masquerading as an employment agency was allegedly trafficking gullible Indian youths to the Golden Triangle Special Economic Zone (SEZ) in Laos via Bangkok. Upon arrival, they were forced to participate in cryptocurrency fraud.



"India must exert diplomatic pressure on the Myanmar and Thai governments to crack down on these illegal operations. Domestically, immigration authorities need to adopt stricter scrutiny"

–GAUTAM MUKHOPADHAYA
Former Indian ambassador to Myanmar

With the NIA investigation illuminating the sheer scale and brutality of this modern-day slavery, the urgent need for global cooperation, stricter enforcement and greater public awareness has never been more evident. On its part, the Indian government has intensified targeted awareness campaigns. Initiatives like SMS alerts, radio campaigns and digital safety weeks, in collaboration with state governments, aim to educate the public about scams, including fake job offers. Notices in newspapers and public spaces further warn citizens.

THE WAY AHEAD

However, challenges persist, particularly in smaller towns like those in Bihar, where unregistered agents facilitate human trafficking, fuelled by high demand for overseas jobs and a lack of strict regulations. The NIA may have made some strides in dismantling such domestic networks, but it has no direct mandate to free those already trapped. Securing their release is a long and arduous process that falls on India's diplomatic channels, requiring backdoor negotiations and sustained efforts. The delays and lack in cooperation have only allowed these scams to continue adapting and evolving.

Mukhopadhaya underscores the need for a comprehensive strategy to tackle the crisis. "India must exert diplomatic pressure on the Myanmar authorities to crack down on these illegal operations," he says. "It's equally important to put pressure on the Thai government, as these activities extend across their borders. Domestically, immigration authorities need to adopt stricter scrutiny—thoroughly questioning individuals travelling to these regions and encouraging them to verify the job offers."

Meanwhile, for those still trapped, like Wahid and Saud, each day deepens their despair, their fates hanging on the whims of the captors. Even for those who return, like Shubham, freedom comes at a cost. The trauma of their ordeal is compounded by financial devastation—savings drained, debts piled high and stability sacrificed to secure their release. The scars of this nightmare extend far beyond the compounds in Myawaddy, haunting homes, futures, and the fragile dreams of those who sought a better life. ■